



The Poll FACTOR

The Congress's hopes of repeating the Lok Sabha results in Maharashtra and Haryana have been dented by reverses in the recent assembly by-elections

| By Priya Sahgal |

There is nothing that Indians love more than elections. And they are not to be blamed. The electoral cycle does not seem to end, ever. The year has already seen general elections as also those to several state assemblies in May; the last fortnight saw by-elections to nearly 50 assembly constituencies and in about three weeks' time, voters in Maharashtra and Haryana will choose their new rulers. Though the polls are to be held on October 13, the results will be awaited for another 10 days. There is a good reason why almost all parties asked the Election Commission to defer the counting till Diwali. The results are likely to impact national politics and nobody wanted the festive season to be spoilt by politicking. Of the two, the more crucial is Maharashtra where the ruling alliance is hoping for a hat-trick. Still beaming with joy over its Lok Sabha win, the Congress first toyed with the idea of going it alone, until it was pulled down to earth by its dismal showing at the recent by-elections held in 12 states where it won only 10 seats. Yet, it bullied its ally, the NCP, into settling for less seats than sought.

Challenging the secular votebank is also the newly-formed Republican Left Democratic Front (RLDF) of 18 parties. For the Opposition, the stakes are higher. This is the ageing Bal Thackeray's last attempt at being rel-

evant while Raj Thackeray's Maharashtra Navnirman Sena still threatens to play spoiler in the Shiv Sena-BJP votebank. The strife-torn BJP knows that a win now would boost the party's morale.

After winning nine of the 10 Lok Sabha seats in the state, a jubilant Congress is almost confident of a cakewalk in Haryana where the chief minister sought another mandate almost a year before it was due. The mood is so upbeat that Delhi's roads are jammed with cavalcades of ticket seekers swarming the Congress headquarters and Haryana Bhavan. The Narnaul constituency, for instance, has as many as 40 aspirants. The break-up of the BJP-Indian National Lok Dal alliance as well as the failure of a tie-up between the Bahujan Samaj Party and Kuldeep Bishnoi's Haryana Janhit Congress has added to the anticipatory celebrations. Devi Lal's son Om Prakash Chautala is desperately looking for one last chance not just to revive his lost legacy, but to ensure that the torch is passed to his

sons Ajay and Abhay while another political inheritor, Bhajan Lal's son Kuldeep Bishnoi, is working overtime to wreak political havoc on the Congress. Traditionally, mid-term assembly elections have rarely been helpful to the party in office at the Centre. The Congress must hope that the trend is reversed this time.

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